Marco | Sage Hill application

1. Your role in Marco's education

What do you see as your main role in your child's education?

Left: complete purple Draft 2 wording. Right: revision built from that draft.
Bold purple = added or rewritten words. Removed wording remains visible on the left. Paragraphs align across columns.

COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
Supporting Marco to achieve goals he sets for himself, staying beside him while he works towards them, is our main role in his educational journey. Marco holds himself to a personal high standard, so he is self-motivated and we rarely need to push him. What he needs from us is patience, practical help, and someone in his corner when it gets hard.	Supporting Marco **as he works toward** goals he sets for **himself** is our main role in his **education.** Marco holds himself to a high **standard and is self-motivated,** so we rarely need to push him. What he needs from us is patience, practical help, and someone in his corner when it gets hard.
Last school year, Marco prepared for his Level 5 Certificate of Merit exam in piano. For his open book theory test, he took a comparable mock test online every day. In all, I printed about twenty practice tests for him. On exam day, I sat next to him with the whole practice pile. When he read a question, he would mark the answer he thought was right and move on, verifying from the practice tests. He caught a few mistakes that way and corrected them. Honestly, I think I was more nervous than he was. He scored over 90 on the theory test, the highest score he had ever reached. His piano teacher told us no one had thought of this idea before, and was impressed.	Last school year, Marco prepared for his Level 5 Certificate of Merit exam in piano. **He took online practice** theory **tests regularly, and** I printed **them** for **him** to **use in his preparation.**
However, the performance proved more challenging. Each piece had to be recorded in one take, with no mistakes, with Marco dressed up and introducing himself on camera. His longest piece being about four minutes. Many times he played for three minutes, slipped in the last measure, and we started over. Often I couldn't even hear the mistake. He could, and he would ask to redo it. Helping him with recording, I held the phone until my hand shook. We fixed the lighting, paused when noise outside interrupted, making sure the house was quiet while we recorded. One piece took a whole week without perfection, so we set it aside, recorded the shorter pieces first, and came back to it a week or two later with more confidence. It took dozens of takes. When he got upset, I didn't tell him to try harder, but reassured him saying, "It's okay. We can record as many times as you want. Mom will be right here. Whenever you feel ready, we'll start." He finished his final recordings in February 2026 and earned excellent ratings in both theory and performance.	**The** performance **recordings** proved more challenging. His longest piece **was** about four minutes. Many times he played for three minutes, slipped in the last measure, and **wanted to start** over. Often I **could not** even hear the **mistake, but he could. We helped with recording** and **kept** the house **quiet. When one** piece **became frustrating,** we set it aside, recorded the shorter pieces first, and came back to it later with more confidence. When he got upset, I **did not** tell him to try **harder. I** reassured **him:** "It's okay. Mom will be right here. Whenever you feel ready, we'll start." He finished his recordings in February 2026 and earned excellent ratings in theory and performance.

1. Your role in Marco's education (continued)

What do you see as your main role in your child's education?

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
We also try to inspire Marco’s curiosity by introducing him to more than he initially expected. Every Saturday, his dad and I spend half a day or more reading his Chinese school lessons with him. He started at the Book 2 level, was named an Outstanding Student in both Book 2 and Book 3, and is now in Book 4. When his class read the story of Tian Ji's horse race, we told him what was happening in China at that time. We did the same with Cai Lun, who invented paper, and Bi Sheng, who invented movable type. When he fell in love with the World Cup, we took him to Dallas to see Cristiano Ronaldo play Portugal's first match. His dad turned it into a quiz: How many teams are playing? Which countries? Which ones are here for the first time? At home, his dad also talks with him about business and personal finance, which genuinely interests Marco.	We also try to **encourage Marco's** curiosity by **exploring his interests together. On Saturdays,** his dad and I **read** his Chinese school lessons with him. When his class read the story of Tian Ji's horse race, we **talked about** what was happening in China at that time. **These conversations connect his language lessons** with **history** and **culture. His interest** in the World **Cup has also led** to **family conversations about the** teams **and countries taking part.** At home, his dad talks with him about business and personal finance, which interests Marco.
For Marco, being there to support his education and curiosity comes from more than just providing the materials or opportunities, it is an active endeavor, taking the whole village, allowing for personal bonding time and helping him achieve the best he can while reassuring him he can get through any challenge he sets for himself.	For **us, supporting** his education **means making time for these conversations, helping when he needs it,** and **giving him room to do** the **work himself. We hope he learns that** he can **work through challenges, take a break when** he **needs one, and ask** for **support without losing ownership of his goals.**

Marco | Sage Hill application

2. Why Sage Hill

Explain your interest in sending your child to Sage Hill.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
A school that encourages students to be independent, individual, and to discover their true self, is what we admire about Sage Hill. Sometimes, Marco needs permission to explore these different areas as he is not a strongly STEM-driven student, leaning towards the humanities, expressing his creativity. In our community, strong students are often expected to follow the same STEM path, participating in math competitions, coding, and engineering. Although Marco could try to fit that mold, his full potential lies elsewhere. When we saw that Sage Hill offers classes in art, business, and entrepreneurship, alongside a rigorous academic program, we thought right away that here he could explore who he actually is, instead of who a strong student is supposed to be.	**We admire Sage Hill's encouragement of** students to **become independent** and discover their **interests. Marco** is **especially drawn to the humanities and creative work. He writes and illustrates comics, enjoys history, and designs projects with friends. We want him to develop these interests while continuing** to explore **a broad academic program. Sage Hill's middle school offerings in visual art, digital art, journalism, and debate connect directly with interests** he **already pursues on** his **own.**
Much of what we know about Sage Hill comes from our colleagues. Darren Chee, whose child attends Sage Hill, was the first to tell us about the school. Later, Jingguang Wang, whose oldest is now in eleventh grade there, told us about their experience with Sage Hill in much greater detail. Several other colleagues we know well also have children there, including Guansheng Li's child in ninth grade and Jingguang's second child in eighth grade. Hearing about their families' real experiences gave us a clear picture of the school.	**We first learned** about Sage Hill from **colleagues** whose **children attend** the school. Hearing about their families' experiences **encouraged** us **to learn more and visit with Marco.**
Among all of this hype, we have visited Sage Hill twice with Marco attending summer camp there and our family attending an Open House. What impressed us most was how teachers, not administrators, approached us first. At the middle school table, a staff member started telling us about the program unprompted and immediately recognized Marco from summer camp. At the History table, the middle school U.S. History teacher explained what seventh graders study. Teacher after teacher asked us what we wanted to know, answering most affectionately. The students there were also incredibly kind, confident, and quick to help families with questions or navigating their way.	Marco **attended** summer camp **at Sage Hill,** and our family **later attended** an Open House. What impressed us most was how **readily teachers** approached **us.** At the middle school table, a staff member **began** telling us about the program and immediately recognized Marco from summer camp. At the History table, the middle school U.S. History teacher explained what seventh graders study. Teacher after teacher **invited our questions and answered warmly.** The students were also kind, confident, and quick to help **visiting families. These encounters made the school feel welcoming and personal.**

Marco | Sage Hill application

2. Why Sage Hill (continued)

Explain your interest in sending your child to Sage Hill.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
When we asked Marco honestly what he likes about Sage Hill, his answer was the cafeteria. He enjoys the food there far more than at his current school. At the fireside chat, students also said they enjoy their school lunch, including lunches for sports teams. It is a small thing, but it is his reason which carries a lot of weight.	When we asked Marco what he **liked** about Sage Hill, his **first** answer was the cafeteria. **We appreciated** his **honest, very practical answer; he already has** his **own reasons to feel comfortable there.**
The Sage Hill brochure says students here create, solve problems, work hard, laugh and explore. When we read that, we thought that this describes Marco. What we want for him is a school as Sage Hill that treats these traits and creative arts not as hobbies adjoined to "real" work, helping Marco reach his full potential on his own path.	The Sage Hill brochure **describes** students **who** create, solve problems, work hard, **laugh,** and explore. When we read that, we **recognized** Marco. **We hope** Sage Hill **will give him opportunities to develop his creativity, contribute his humor** and **ideas, and grow through relationships with teachers and classmates who come** to **know him well.**

3. Parent volunteering and community involvement

As the parent(s), please describe any volunteer work, service activities, or community involvement you have participated in.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
Every year, at Marco's school Jog-A-Thon every year I volunteer. During his first Jog-A-Thon, after noticing there were very few parents helping out and the staff were short-handed, I picked up one of the spare pens and started marking laps for the kids as they ran. Normally, parents sign up through the PTA, however my introduction was through filling a need. This is our approach and attitude we also want to instill in Marco.	**I volunteer** at Marco's school Jog-A-Thon **each year. At the first event** I **helped with, I noticed** there were few parents **assisting** and the staff were short-handed, **so** I picked up **a** spare **pen** and **began** marking laps for the **children** as they ran. **That experience reflects an** attitude we **hope** to instill in **Marco: notice where help is needed and contribute.**
At SCJFL speech and debate tournaments, Marco's father volunteers as a judge. Marco competes in SCJFL, and even though he is only in sixth grade, he already qualifies for the middle school division. As a result, his father judges middle school events, including debate and impromptu speaking. A tournament takes a long day, and he sees many students from many schools and backgrounds. What stays with Marco’s father most is their confidence, how sharp and well organized many of them are, their determination, and thorough preparation. Besides scoring rounds, he enjoys giving each student personalized feedback to encourage them with what went well and help with constructive criticism for what to work on next time.	**Marco's father volunteers as a judge at** SCJFL speech and debate tournaments, **including** middle school debate and impromptu **speaking events.** A tournament takes a long **day** and **brings together** students from many schools and backgrounds. Besides scoring rounds, he enjoys giving each student personalized feedback **on** what went well and what to work on next time. **He values the opportunity to support students as they develop their confidence and communication skills.**
This November, our whole family has signed up for Love Irvine's Serve Day. We will join the Rocks of Encouragement project, painting rocks with simple handmade messages for seniors in our city, many of whom live with isolation. We chose a project Marco and Harry can do with their own hands, so that the drawing Marco loves can bring a little joy and connection to someone who needs it. At Sage Hill, we hope to continue this spirit of volunteering, helping out wherever there is a need, whether it is in the classroom, for a Sage Hill school event, an academic or sporting competition, or doing what is needed to help spread love and joy to those who are suffering.	**Our** whole family has **also** signed up for Love Irvine's Serve **Day this November.** We **plan to** join the Rocks of Encouragement project, painting rocks with handmade messages for seniors in our **city who may be experiencing** isolation. We chose a project Marco and Harry can **participate in directly, using Marco's love of** drawing **to** bring **encouragement** to **others.** At Sage Hill, we hope to continue **contributing our time to school events, student activities, and community service** wherever **we can be useful.**

4. Marco's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses

Describe your child's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
Marco is a creative, talented, and funny boy who always finishes whatever he starts. On the other hand, his strengths sometimes cause him to inflict too much pressure on himself.	Marco is a creative, **persistent,** and funny boy who **takes pride in** his **work. His high standards help him follow through, but they can also lead** him to **put** too much pressure on himself.
For instance, Marco went from white to black belt in taekwondo in only two years. Many of his friends quit along the way, however he loved it, and once he started, he wanted to continue to achieve the greatest honor. He won a gold medal at a tournament, and in 2025 he won a silver medal at the Annual Kukkiwon World Taekwondo competition. For that event, he made up every move of his routine himself. Their studio encourages students to enter, but does not coach them. At the competition, each of the other five to ten students in his group had a coach next to them who had put their routine together and kept calling out, "Louder!" or "Higher!" Marco walked in alone, competed without a coach, and did not freeze once. He was not expecting a medal, just to do his best, so he was overjoyed to come home with silver.	**His persistence shows in taekwondo. He** went from white **belt** to black belt in two **years and continued because** he loved **it. He has earned gold** and **silver medals, including** a silver **in 2025.** For that event, he **put together** his **own** routine and competed without a **coach beside him.** He **went in hoping** to do his **best and** was overjoyed to come home with **a medal.**
In fourth grade, Marco tested into APAAS, Irvine's program for advanced students, which meant changing schools and leaving his old classmates. The schoolwork is more challenging, but when he gets home, he does his homework and prepares for tests on his own and he has kept his grades up. For a U.S. history project, he wrote and illustrated his own booklet, "The Wars of the American Revolution." He also writes creatively and often gets full marks on his writing exams. This creativity of his shows up everywhere. Since he was five, he has created his own books making everything himself from writing the story, drawing the illustrations, even binding the pages together.	In fourth grade, Marco **entered** APAAS, Irvine's program for advanced students, which meant changing schools and leaving his old classmates. **He has managed the** more **challenging work while doing** his homework and **preparing** for tests **independently. Writing** and **history are particular interests.** For a U.S. history project, he wrote and illustrated his own booklet, "The Wars of the American Revolution." Since he was five, he has **also made** his own **books,** writing the **stories,** drawing the illustrations, **and** binding the pages together.

4. Marco's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses (continued)

Describe your child's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
In first and second grade, he wrote a whole comic series called Marshmallow and Onion, and in third grade he wrote its ending. This led to him creating a second series, "The Adventure of Coral the Axolotl," this time with a friend who drew the pictures. He asked to take art lessons when he was three and a half, and has won two art contest awards. This fall, his sixth-grade class did self-introductions, and each student brought three things. Marco brought a watercolor he painted at summer art camp. His teacher chose his painting, out of all the student's items, to display in the classroom.	In first and second grade, he wrote a comic series called Marshmallow and **Onion** and **completed its ending** in third **grade. He later created** "The Adventure of Coral the **Axolotl"** with a friend who drew the pictures. He **has continued taking** art lessons and has won two art contest awards. This fall, **he brought a watercolor from summer art camp to** his sixth-grade class **introduction,** and **his** teacher chose to display **it** in the classroom.
Recently Marco and a close friend in his class decided to start a company. Marco draws turtle designs, classmates pick the turtles they enjoy most, and the boys 3D-print them at home. Marco also drew the logo and the flyer, and they priced each turtle using their school's reward tickets "Gotchas." They sold so many turtles, collecting so many Gotchas, that the principal found out and unfortunately put a stop to it.	**Recently,** Marco and a close friend **designed and 3D-printed turtles for classmates.** Marco **drew the** designs, **logo, and flyer,** and the boys **priced** the **turtles in** their school's reward **tickets, called "Gotchas." The school later stopped** the **sales. The project brought together several of his interests: making things, sharing ideas with a friend,** and **finding an audience for his designs.**
When we met with his principal, the principal told us Marco is very articulate, and he now competes in speech and debate in the middle school division.	**His** principal **has remarked on how articulate he is, and** Marco now competes in speech and debate in the middle school division.
He is a kind friend, too. Once a close friend told him she liked frogs. We bought him fabric and cotton, and he sat at home sewing. When we asked what he was doing, he said, "Sewing a frog." Only later did we learn it was a gift for her.	He is a **thoughtful** friend, too. **After** a close friend **mentioned that** she liked **frogs, he sewed a frog for her from** fabric and **cotton. We only learned** later **that** it was a **gift.**

4. Marco's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses (continued)

Describe your child's academic and personal strengths and weaknesses.

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
Humor has always been an important aspect of Marco’s life. In first through third grade, it felt like the whole grade knew him, because he made everyone laugh. It is not just that he tells jokes, what stands out is that he does something unexpected, and is comfortable doing these silly absurd things in front of other people to make them laugh. This fall, at one of the Friday all-school assemblies on the field, the principal asked for volunteers to see who could jump the highest. Marco volunteered. When his turn came, he jumped, then broke into a few moves of "Ke Mu San," a silly dance that went viral in China, which he probably picked up online. The students all burst out laughing, and Harry, watching from the crowd, thought it was hilarious.	Humor **is another part** of **Marco's personality. He** is comfortable **being playful** in front of **others. At an all-school assembly this** fall, **he volunteered** for **a jumping activity,** then **added** a few moves of **the** "Ke Mu **San" dance.** The students burst out laughing, and **his little brother Harry** thought it was hilarious.
With all of his efforts and success, he sometimes is very hard on himself. When he is close to completing something and makes one small mistake, such as slipping in the last measure of a piano piece, he may yell and ask himself what might be wrong with his hand. Never angry towards other people, his only anger has been towards himself. We have learned that pushing or lecturing does not help him, instead giving him space helps him calm down and work through it on his own. Marco has gotten much better at coping through mistakes. He has started to see each mistake as a step or opportunity rather than a disaster. Now, more often than not, he says, "We need to redo it," and simply restarts. When something does not work, he pauses, putting whatever project aside for a time, returning to it later instead of forcing it. Although frustration still shows up sometimes, it passes faster, and he goes back to his work level-headed. We think he is learning the hardest lesson for a perfectionist: when to keep pushing and when to let go, and that mistakes are opportunities for growth.	**His main area for growth** is **handling mistakes without becoming too** hard on himself. **A** small **slip near** the **end** of a piano **piece can leave him frustrated** and **self-critical.** We have learned that giving him space helps **more than pushing or lecturing. He is getting** better at **pausing, setting a difficult project aside, and returning** to **it later. More** often **now,** he **simply** says, "We need to redo it," and **starts again. Frustration** still **occurs, but** it passes **faster. He** is learning when to keep **trying,** when to **take a break,** and **how to accept** mistakes **as part of learning.**

5. Additional information

Is there any additional information that you would like to provide to the Admission Committee?

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COUNSELOR'S VERSION	MY REVISED VERSION
Marco’s little brother Harry is his shadow. If Marco does something, Harry also does it without question. If we ask Harry to do something Marco isn't doing, the first thing he says is, "Why doesn't Marco have to?" Marco knows this, and he leads by example, bringing Harry along for chores, exercise, and even sitting down to do homework. When the two of them are fighting over something, everyone yelling, Marco holds back. Although Marco may be very upset, he is still careful with his brother. As parents, we admire this aspect of Marco. Sometimes, when both boys are in the middle of a game or a TV show, Marco suddenly gets up and leaves. When we ask where he is going, he says, "Homework." This is a level of self-control and time management that plenty of us adults cannot even do.	**We would also like to share a little about Marco as a big brother and grandson. His** little brother Harry is his shadow. If Marco does something, Harry **usually wants** to do **it too.** Marco knows **this** and leads by example, bringing Harry along for chores, exercise, and homework. **Even when** the **brothers disagree and** Marco **is** upset, he is careful with **Harry. We also notice** his **growing independence: sometimes he gets up** in the middle of a game or **television** show, and **when** we ask where he is going, he **simply** says, "Homework."
Last winter we spent two weeks traveling in China with my parents, who Marco is very close to. We had two rooms, one for our nuclear family and one for my parents. Marco chose to stay in his grandparents' room all fourteen nights. In the evenings they talked and played cards or games together. My parents reflected that they could feel how much Marco loves them. Back home, Marco is always the first one to ask to call his Grandma and Grandpa, even if there is no special reason for the call. Whenever Marco plays a piano piece well or gets a good grade in school, he immediately wants to share the news with his grandparents.	**Marco is very close to his grandparents.** Last **winter,** we spent two weeks traveling in China with my **parents.** We had two rooms, and Marco chose to stay in his grandparents' room all fourteen nights. In the **evenings,** they talked and played cards or games together. My parents **told us** they could feel how much **he** loves them. Back home, Marco is **often** the first to **suggest calling** Grandma and **Grandpa. When he** plays a piano piece well or **earns** a good **grade,** he wants to share the news with **them.**
This kindness is something his teachers have remarked on as well. At a Community Rocks school event, his teacher Ms. Minna Morikawa half-jokingly asked Marco and two friends to save her a piece of candy. They ran off and came back with two treats for her. She later wrote to our families that the photo she took of the boys with the candies is one of her favorites because their joy showed so clearly and makes her feel fortunate to be their teacher. Marco’s kindness, care, and attention to others is something that no words can really express, but it is something that will only bring kindness, happiness, and joy to the greater Sage Hill Community.	**These everyday moments show** a **side of** Marco **that grades** and **activities cannot fully capture. He values being close** to the **people he loves and finds small ways to show them that he cares.**

Review notes before submission

The right column is an edited review draft. These notes are for the family and counselor; they are not part of the application responses.

What was preserved - The five original prompts, the counselor's structure, and many original sentences remain. The left column reproduces all purple Draft 2 wording, with line breaks and paragraph groupings adjusted for comparison. Bold purple on the right marks changed or added words; unchanged wording stays black. No new awards, experiences, or reactions by Marco have been invented.

1. Education: exam account and independence - The revision keeps the piano practice and recording story, but omits the actual theory-exam answer-checking account. The earlier black draft attributes some answer-checking to a parent; the purple draft attributes it to Marco. Confirm the facts and the exam's permitted assistance before using that account anywhere. The recording story already illustrates patient support. Match the exact rating language to his results if needed.

2. Sage Hill: specific middle school connections - The revision replaces the STEM comparison and list of colleagues' names with Marco's existing interests and the family's visits. Sage Hill's published middle school FAQ lists visual art, digital art, journalism, and debate. Business and entrepreneurship are not listed there, so those claims were removed. Availability for Marco's entry year should be checked before submission. Source: sagehillschool.org/admission/middle-school (reviewed October 26, 2026).

3. Service: timing and frequency - The November Love Irvine activity remains a future plan because this draft is dated October 26. If submitted after the event, update the passage only after confirming what the family actually did. Add accurate years or frequency for the Jog-A-Thon and judging if useful; no quantities were invented.

4. Strengths and growth: factual precision - Confirm the 2025 taekwondo event's official title and category against his certificate; the notes and essay use different descriptions. The revision uses a general description. It retains the turtle project and the fact that the school stopped sales, without guessing why or inventing a lesson learned. A brief, accurate account of Marco's response could strengthen it. The revision preserves frustration as an honest area for growth and the coping strategies already described.

5. Additional information: family relationships - The grandparents and younger-brother stories remain. The teacher-and-candy anecdote and broad concluding praise were shortened to let the family examples carry the message.

Final family check - Confirm that every sentence reflects your experience and sounds like you. Check the application portal's actual word or character limits; none were provided in the source PDF. The right-column counts below are approximate and exclude these notes.

Approximate word counts, counselor to revision: Q1: 589 to 345 | Q2: 436 to 278 | Q3: 309 to 215 | Q4: 876 to 528 | Q5: 374 to 219